



THE CULT MODI OF

CARICATURED AS A MONSTER AND MARKETING AS A MODERNISER, THE POSTER BOY OF HINDU MACHISMO IS THE ONLY ISSUE IN THE CAMPAIGN. INSIDE THE WHIRL OF FORCE MODI.

■ By S. Prasannarajan

The colour of that shawl he flips across his shoulder with such dramatic flourish is a shade deeper than the saffron in which this night is painted. The words he utters in a modulated voice carry more electricity than the farmers of Gujarat get from his much-hyped power reform. The enemies his stump speeches unravel are a threat to the survival of the nation. The gods he wants to save from the profanities of the secular establishment are an endangered lot, banished from the sacred text of the Hindu to the depths of the Palk Strait. The world he promises from the illuminated podium inundated with lotuses is a place where men and their reinstated gods will live in harmony, and where terrorists with names like Sohrabuddin won't be worshipped—have no fear—no matter what the “sultanate of Delhi” will do to him. Well, they can “hang me”. Tonight, though, he has dreams to sell, nightmares to share, deities to defend, demons to exorcise, and, incidentally, an election to win. “And everyone says elections are never won on development. O really! I'll prove them wrong...You prove them wrong”,